



BANGALORE | Snowball Effect

The Mangalore pub incident has shocked all of India and sent the BJP and its allies scurrying for cover after a volley of criticism from all quarters. In an event that shook civil society, members of the Sri Rama Sena (SRS) entered Amnesia, a pub in Mangalore, and assaulted a group of men and women for “indulging in activities that did not conform with Indian culture”. What incensed this self-appointed moral police was not just the fact that women were drinking alcohol in a pub, but that they were fraternising with Muslim men. The BJP quickly distanced itself from the affair, claiming that the SRS is neither a faction of the BJP nor of the Sangh Parivar. BJP President Rajnath Singh rushed to Bangalore to control the damage. Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa said strong action would be taken against the hoodlums, some of whom have been arrested. SRS founder Pramod Mutalik was arrested in Belgaum on January 27 for making an inflammatory speech in Davanagere earlier this month. SRS and another Bajrang Dal faction that claimed responsibility for the attack insist on continuing their offensive against “pub culture”. Local journalists who knew about the attacks but didn’t tip off the police have also been booked. This is the latest of many incidents in Karnataka where TV channels are informed before ‘activists’ go on the rampage to ensure media coverage. *by Nirmala Ravindran*

**SRI RAM SENA
ACTIVISTS
ATTACK WOMEN
AT A PUB IN
MANGALORE**

26

so-called
activists of
the Sri Rama
Sena have
been arrested
for assaulting
women in a
pub even as
the BJP has
distanced
itself from the
incident.